

Practice Paper 15 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “A bored diver is a curious diver”

Award **1 mark** for understanding that the familiar reef no longer held her interest; **1 mark** for explaining that this boredom **pushed** her to explore unfamiliar ground.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that because the reef had become **too familiar** to excite her any longer, the narrator was **driven by restlessness** to look for something new — and that very curiosity led her further along the wall than usual.

Q2. [2] — Reef felt familiar and unremarkable

1 mark each for any two of:

- The fusiliers wheeled past in their “usual silver hurry”.
- A pair of clownfish “bickered with their anemone” (a routine sight).
- The sand sloped down to twenty metres as it always did.
- She had “long since stopped finding” the deep blue darkness frightening.
- She describes herself as “bored”.

Q3. [2] — Water seeming to “exhale”

1 mark for identifying **personification** — the water is given a human / living action of breathing out.

1 mark for explaining the **effect**: it makes the cave feel **alive** and **inviting**, almost as if it were beckoning her in, and suggests a slow, gentle current emerging from the gap.

Q4. [2] — Chamber compared to “a small chapel”

1 mark — A chapel suggests a **quiet, sacred, reverent** space; the comparison shows she feels a sense of **awe** and **holiness** inside the cave.

1 mark — It also implies that she has stepped into somewhere **hushed and special**, set apart from the noisy ordinary world above.

Q5. [2] — Panic in Paragraph 4

(a) [1]: The word **uncoiled** suggests panic is like a **snake** lying still inside her — it had been **waiting**, and is now slowly **releasing itself** / **spreading** through her chest, which makes it feel dangerous and instinctive.

(b) [1]: Any **one** of:

- She “forced [her]self to breathe slowly through the regulator”.
- She remembered the instructors’ training: “In. Hold. Out.”
- The light “steadied” and “so did I”.

Q6. [3] — Awe and contrast in Paragraph 5 (language question)

1 mark for identifying the **contrast** between the timeless, untouched cave and the busy, modern world above; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “untouchedness” — the invented word emphasises that **no one** has ever disturbed the chamber, making it feel pure and rare.
- “No diver’s fin had stirred the silt... No careless hand had snapped one of the stone fingers” — the parallel negatives stress the **absence of human interference**.
- “waiting, quite patiently, in the dark” — personifies the cave as patient and almost wise, emphasising how long it has been alone.
- “while the world above it had invented telephones and aeroplanes and forgotten how to keep a secret” — the listing of human inventions sets the **busy, talkative** surface world against the **silent, secret** cave.
- “the most fortunate person alive” — the hyperbole conveys the depth of her awe.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — Determination to leave the cave undisturbed

1 mark each for any two of:

- She “took no photographs”.
- She “touched nothing”.
- She moved “very slowly” so her fins would not lift the silt.
- She stayed only “perhaps eight minutes” — a deliberately short visit.

Q8. [2] — “A small, bright coin”

1 mark — The comparison suggests the discovery is **precious** / **valuable** — something one might keep and treasure.

1 mark — **Small** and **bright** together suggest something **easy to lose** if spent (spoken) carelessly; she is aware of how **temptingly easy** it would be to share it.

Q9. [1] — Effect of short, separate sentences

1 mark — The short, **fragmented** sentences mimic the narrator’s **quick, vivid mental images** of what would happen if she revealed the cave; they create **emphasis** and a sense of **dread**, listing the consequences one stark image at a time.

Q10. [2] — “A sleeping child”

1 mark — A sleeping child is **vulnerable** and easily disturbed; the comparison shows the narrator now sees the cave as something **fragile** that must be protected.

1 mark — It also suggests **affection** and **tenderness** — she feels a quiet, protective love for it, like that of a parent or guardian.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **peaceful, contented, reflective, serene, quietly resolute**. (Reject: **sad, regretful** — these miss the calm acceptance.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “A quiet act of disruption”

1 mark for understanding **quiet** — the tourist does not **intend** harm and is not **visibly** destructive.

1 mark for understanding **disruption** — yet the cumulative effect of so many tourists is to **unsettle** / **damage** the daily life of the place they visit.

Together: the modern tourist causes **unintended, gradual harm** simply by being one of many.

Q13. [2] — How short-term rental platforms have changed

1 mark each for any two of:

- They were originally a way for **ordinary people** to make a **little extra** income from a **spare room**.
- They have grown into a **sprawling, semi-professional industry**.
- **Whole apartment blocks** are now **stripped** from the long-term rental market.
- They have **converted housing** into **year-round lodging for tourists**.

Q14. [1] — Effect of inverted commas around “concept”

1 mark — The inverted commas show the writer is using the word **ironically** / **with scepticism**; he doubts that these new cafes really embody any meaningful “concept” — they are essentially **gimmicks** designed for tourists, not genuine local establishments.

Q15. [2] — “A costumed performance of her culture”

1 mark — **Costumed** and **performance** suggest something **theatrical, fake, and put on for an audience** — not the lived, everyday version of the culture.

1 mark — The writer is therefore **critical** / **regretful**: he sees the change as turning a real, living culture into a **commercial show**, in which authenticity is lost and what remains is sold back to locals at inflated prices.

Q16. [2] — “A peculiar accelerant to this fire”

1 mark — A **fire** is something already burning — the writer is saying the cultural damage of tourism was **already happening**.

1 mark — An **accelerant** is something added to make a fire spread **much faster**; **social media** has therefore **intensified and sped up** an existing problem, making damage occur far more quickly than before.

Q17. [1] — Tone of “famous for being photographed”

1 mark — Any **one** of: **ironic, wry, critical, sardonic**. (Also accept: **bemused**. Reject: **angry, bitter**.)

Q18. [2] — Visitors who clog roads and pay school fees

1 mark — The writer is highlighting a **contradiction** / **dilemma**: the **same people** who cause the problem also **fund local life**.

1 mark — He places the two ideas side by side to show that tourism cannot simply be condemned, because for many places its **harms** and **benefits** come from **exactly the same source**.

Q19. [2] — “Quietness, scarcity, dignity”

(a) [1]: Any **one** of **quietness**, **scarcity**, or **dignity** — none is a physical good that can normally be bought, used up or replaced.

(b) [1]: By calling them **resources**, the writer suggests that these intangible qualities are **finite** and can be **exhausted** by overuse, just like water or land; this **reframes** them as things that have a real cost, which a visitor should be expected to **pay for**.

Q20. [2] — “The uncomfortable point”

1 mark — **Uncomfortable** shows the writer recognises the **unfairness** of pricing some travellers out, and that this is a **morally awkward** admission.

1 mark — Yet he believes it is **necessary**: it is the **honest** conclusion that follows from accepting that places, like resources, are **not endlessly renewable**. He is asking readers to face an uneasy truth rather than avoid it.

Q21. [2] — The closing argument

1 mark — The sentence captures the writer’s **core principle**: a visitor’s **responsibility** is to **leave a place as they found it** — i.e. to avoid lasting harm.

1 mark — Where harm is unavoidable, the writer argues the visitor should **compensate** for it financially — neatly summarising his case that **thoughtful regulation and fees**, not bans, are the most reasonable response to mass tourism.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Cultural and social harms (Paragraphs 2–4):

1. Whole apartment blocks have been **removed from long-term housing** and turned into tourist lodging.
2. **Rents have risen sharply** for local residents (e.g. nearly 70 per cent in central Lisbon over a decade).
3. Neighbourhoods **lose their local identity**: grocers, bakeries and laundries are **replaced** by souvenir shops, gift cafes and storage offices.
4. Local culture is reduced to a **fake** / **staged version** sold back to residents, while the **real culture retreats** to suburbs.
5. **Social media** draws sudden, overwhelming crowds to previously quiet places, forcing emergency local measures (traffic lights, barriers, ticketing).

Measures cities and countries have begun to take (Paragraphs 5–6):

6. Cities such as **Amsterdam** have **banned new hotels** in the centre and **capped cruise traffic**.
7. **Venice** now **charges day-trippers an entry fee** on peak days.

8. **Bhutan** requires foreign visitors to pay a **daily sustainability fee** that funds **schools, hospitals and conservation**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Mass tourism has caused serious harm because short-term rentals have stripped flats from residents, pushing local rents sharply higher. Neighbourhood grocers and bakeries are replaced by souvenir shops and gift cafes, so local culture survives only as a staged show. Viral posts also flood once-quiet sites with sudden crowds. In response, cities are limiting new hotels and cruise ships, charging day-trippers entry fees, and, in Bhutan, demanding a daily levy that funds schools, hospitals and conservation.

Length count: 78 words from “Mass” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —